

From Mark-Making to Meaning-Making: Exploring a Multimodal Chatbot as a Facilitator in Therapeutic Art Activity

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DIS'26 WiP Paper

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Bridging Drawing and Reflective Dialogue

Therapeutic art helps people externalize feelings that are difficult to express verbally.



Gap: Existing systems rarely connect dialogue directly to the evolving visual metaphors on the canvas.

Our prototype explores:

**Free-form
drawing canvas**

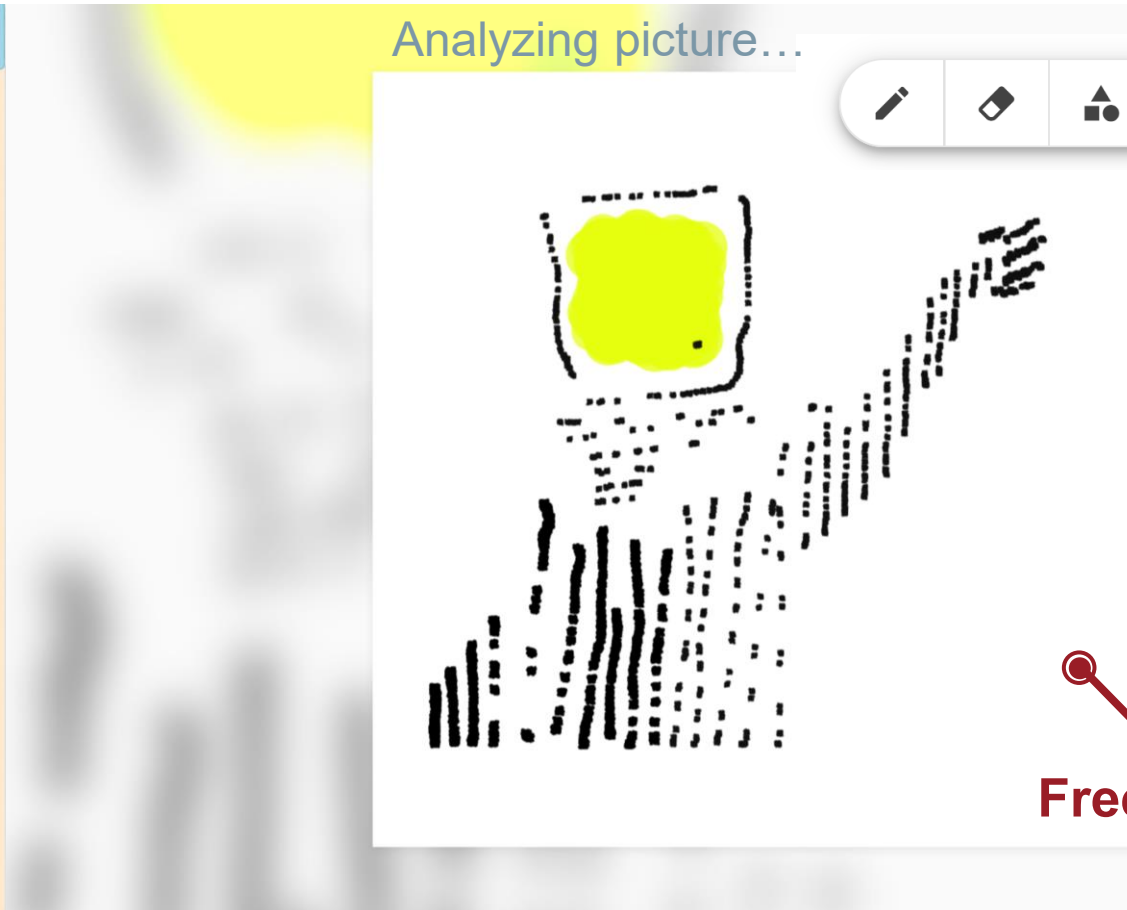
**Real-time
visual understanding**

Reflective dialogue

Reflective dialogue



Real-time visual understanding

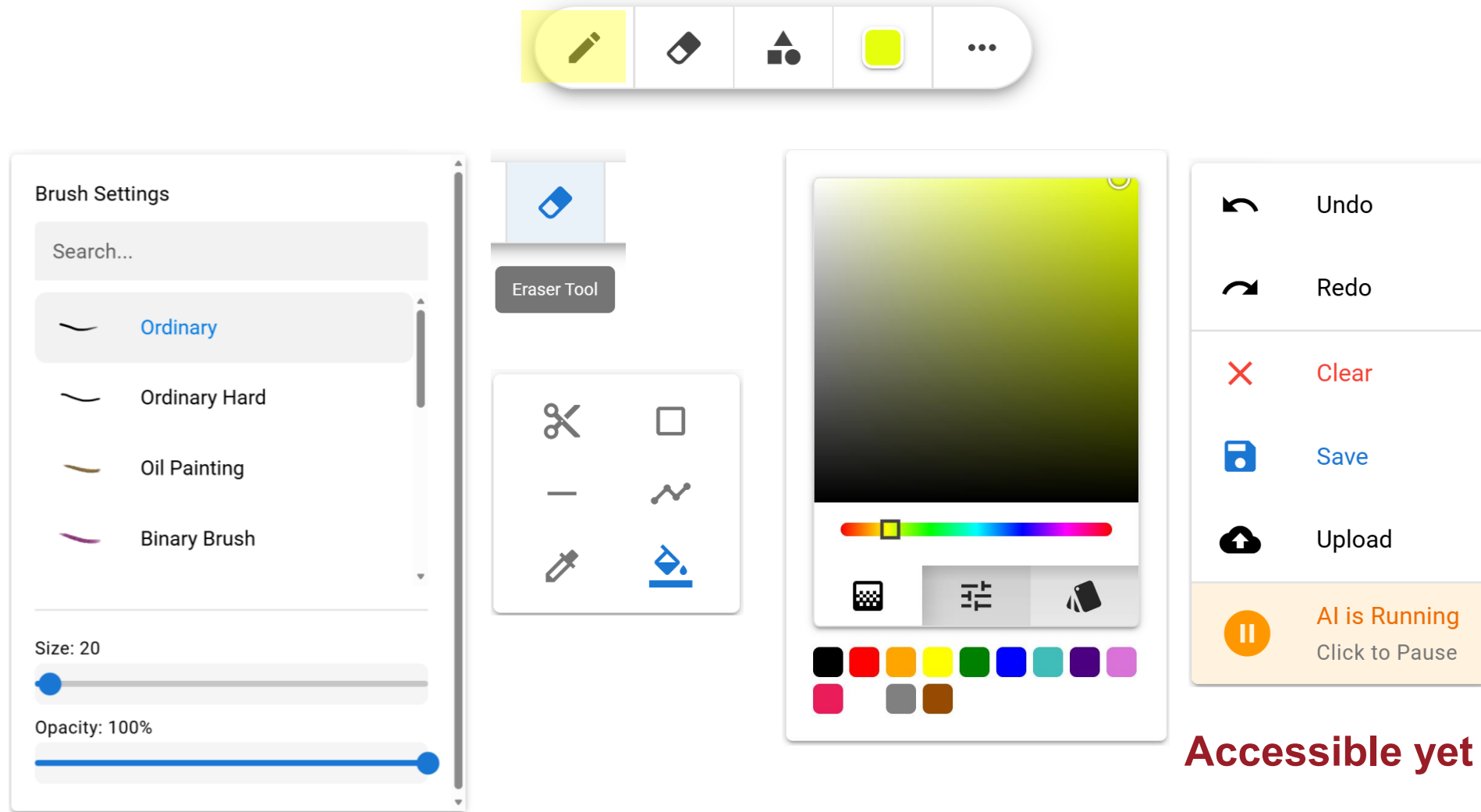


Drawing toolkit

Free-form drawing canvas

Prototype Overview

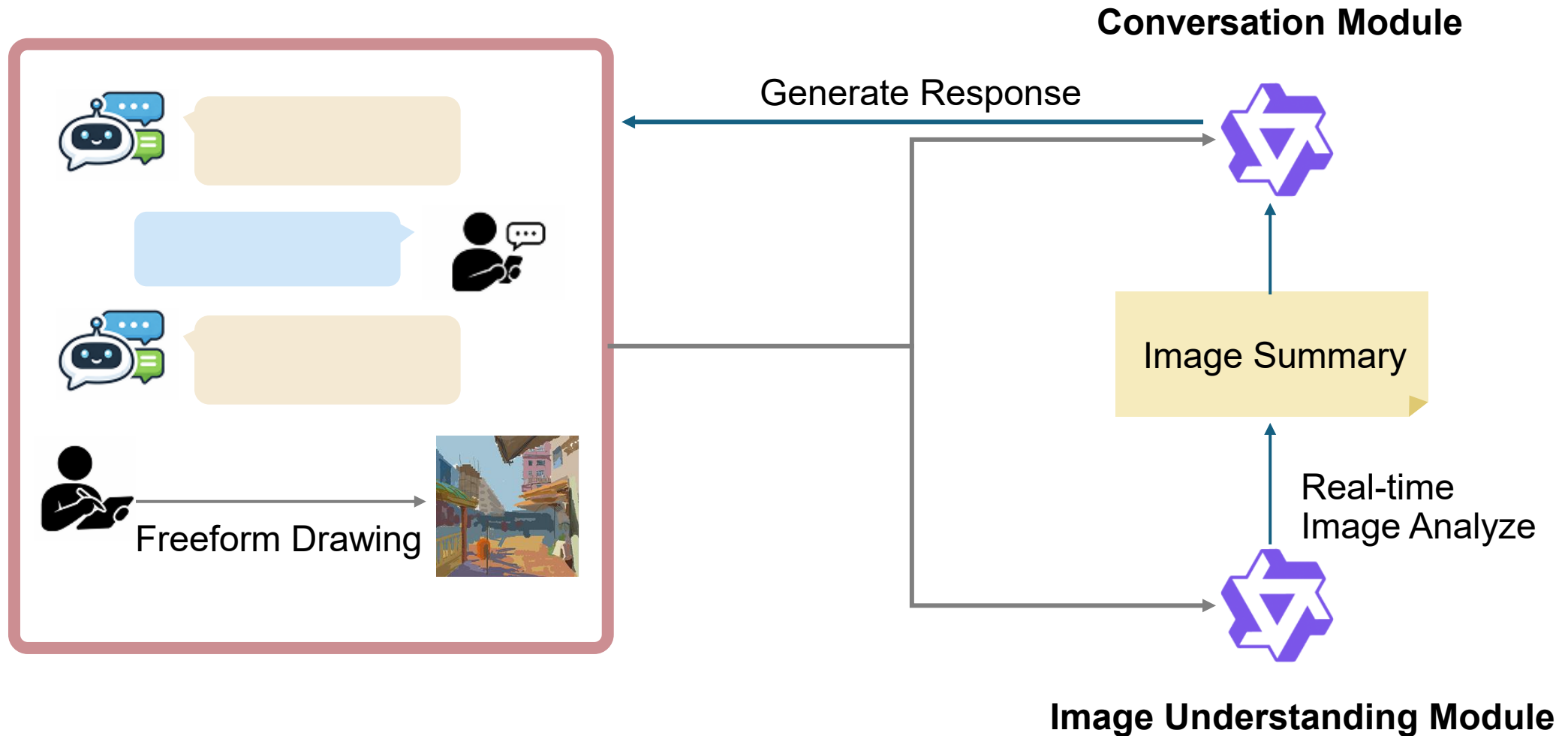
Connecting drawing, visual understanding, and reflective dialogue



Accessible yet expressive

A Free-Form Creative Workspace

System Overview



Expert Evaluation

- Participants: 5 art therapists or related fields

Table 1: Participants' demographic information.

ID	Gender/ Age	Background	Relevant Experience	Specialized Areas
P1	F/31	Healing Arts Practitioner	1 year	Stress management
P2	F/32	Certificated Art Therapist	1 year	Chronic mental condition management
P3	M/23	Healing Arts Practitioner	1 year	Psychological projection; drawing- & olfactory-based healing activity
P4	F/27	Healing Arts Practitioner	3 years	Geopsychology; drawing- & crafting-based healing activity
P5	F/30	Dancer & graduate student in Expressive Arts Therapy	10 years/6 months	Emotion expression through dancing & drawing activity

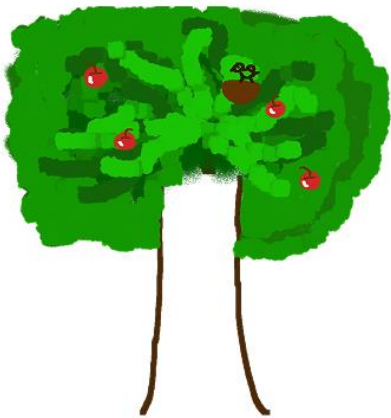


Preliminary Findings

Positive Outlook:

- Low-stakes entry point for emotional expression
- Effective visual comprehension
- Supportive therapeutic dialogue

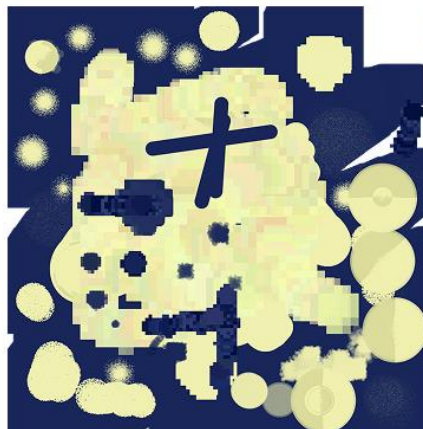
P1



P2



P3



P4



P5



Effective visual comprehension

Analyzing picture...

I have no idea what to draw...
what should I do?



That's okay. The moment of not knowing is often the most authentic. You've already drawn this **tiny purple dot**—existing quietly like a seed, or a gentle 'I am here.'

Would you like to sit with it for a while?
Perhaps ask it: 'Why are you here?' or
'What do you want to grow into?'



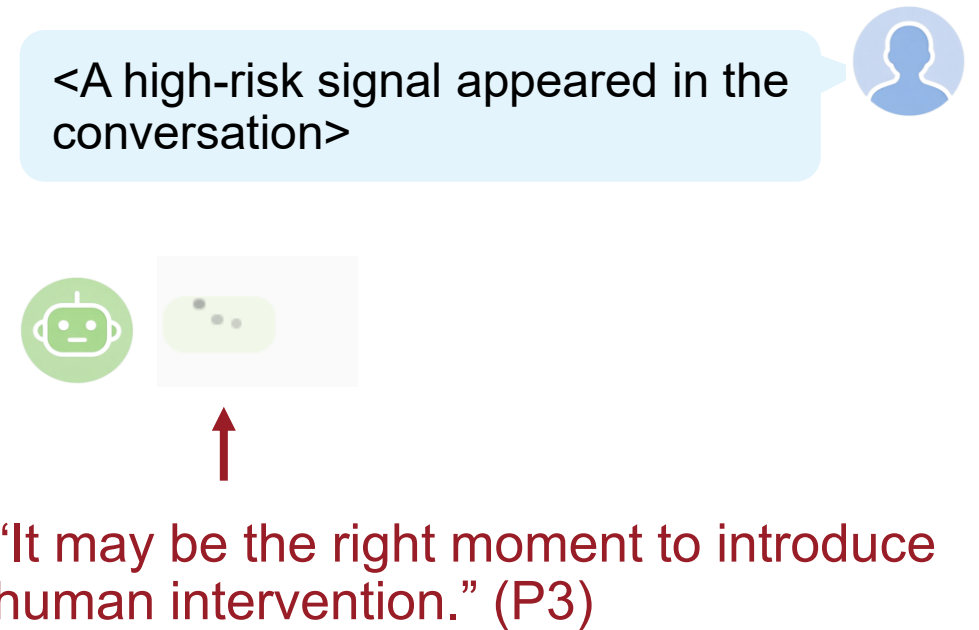
Preliminary Findings

Potential risks & improvements:

- Detecting Risks and Escalating to Human Support
- Aligning AI Therapeutic Responses with User Profiles
- Balancing Therapeutic Depth and Width
- Enriching Visual Interactivity

Detecting Risks and Escalating to Human Support

- **Before interaction:**
Pre-screen users who may not be suitable for unguided AI-led reflection.
- **During interaction:**
Detect high-risk signals (e.g., anger, distress, or suicidal ideation) and introduce human support when needed.



Aligning AI Therapeutic Responses with User Profiles

Therapist-side customization

- Different therapeutic style:
Psychodynamic / Humanistic / Narrative /
Cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT)

“I would prefer a therapist who also understands dancing.” (P5)

User-side personalization

- User background
(e.g., age, cultural background, art experience, communication style)
- Long-term memory
(Chat history, preferences)



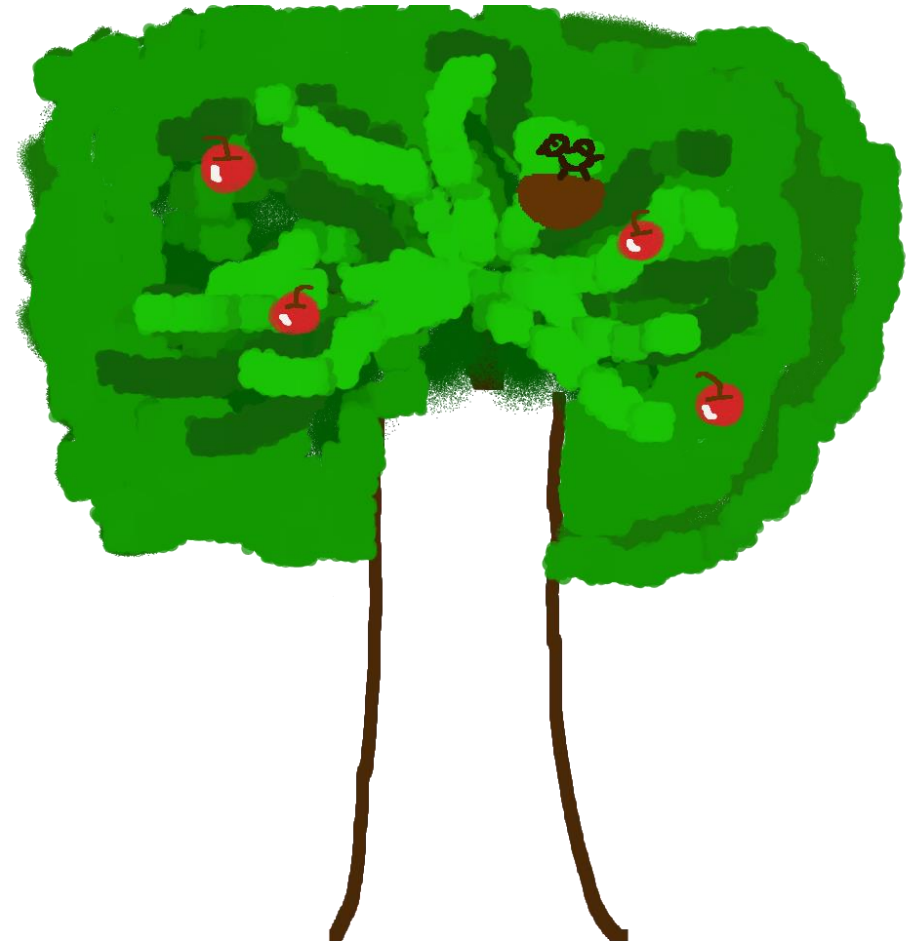
Adaptive AI style
Tailored tone, prompts, and interaction strategy

Balancing Therapeutic Depth and Width

- Questions should move from the big picture to smaller pieces.



Would you like to start with the overall shape of the trees?



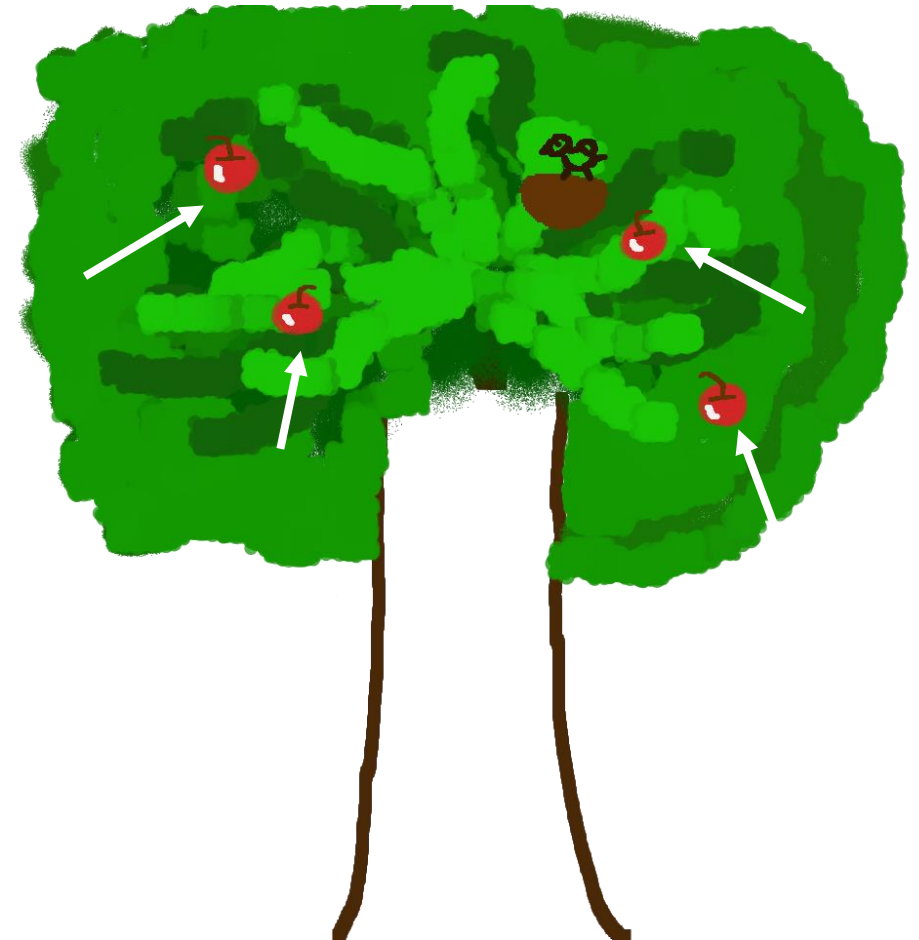
Balancing Therapeutic Depth and Width

- Questions should move from the big picture to smaller pieces.



I notice several red fruits among the green leaves. What do these fruits mean to you?

Is there one fruit that feels more important than the others?



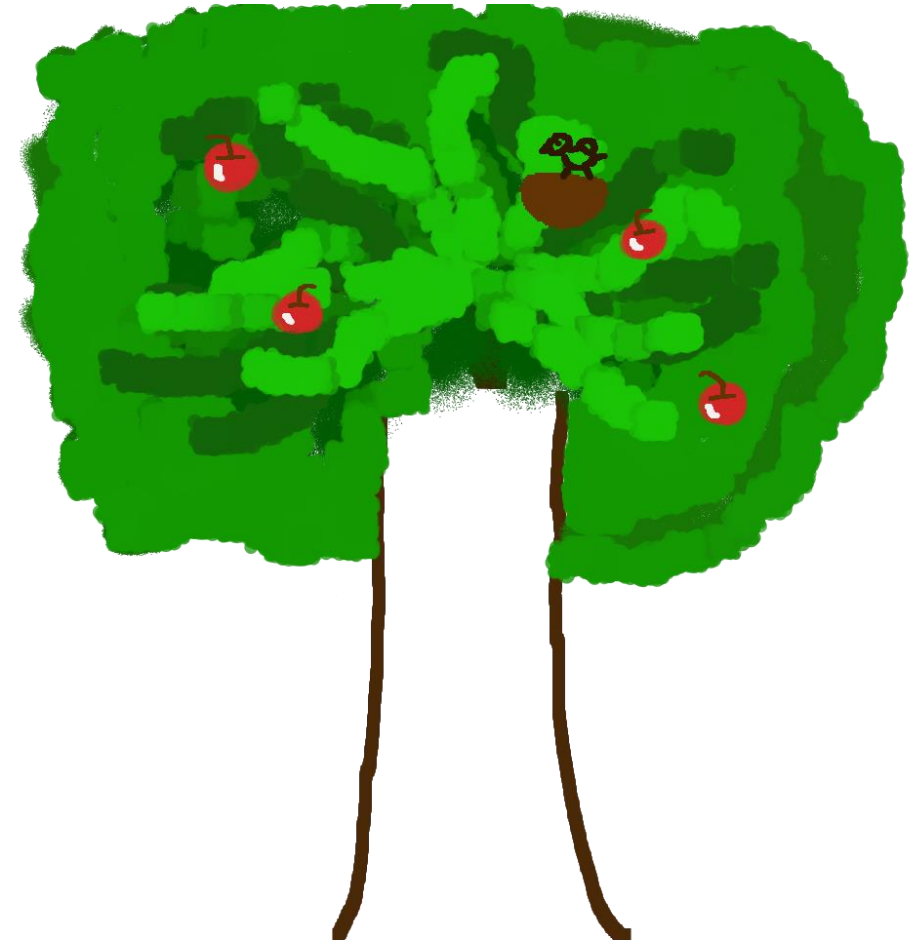
Balancing Therapeutic Depth and Width

- Questions should move from the big picture to smaller pieces.



The tree crowns look very dense and large.
What feeling does this dense green area give you?

...



Balancing Therapeutic Depth and Width

- Give users more space for imagination rather than limiting their thoughts in one box.

I don't really have any direction.



Having no direction can also be a kind of direction — **like** the sea late at night, seemingly still but carrying the rhythm of the tides...

The AI's interpretation gave me a direction to think from, but also introduced a subtle form of resistance.



Enriching Visual Interactivity

- Engage with specific visual elements by **high lighting** or **masking** regions directly on the canvas for discussion.

“For example, with something like this, I feel there could be many interpretations. If I were the person drawing it, I might see it as a wisp of smoke, or maybe as a leaf, or perhaps as a floating ribbon.”
(P5)



Would you like to say more about this highlighted part?

Future Directions: From Chatbot to Responsible Creative Partner

Safety & Boundaries

- *When should AI start, stop, or hand off?*

Conversation Trajectory

- *How can AI balance depth and width without over-interpreting?*

Adaptive Therapeutic Style

- *How can AI adapt to different users and practices?*

Visual Co-Creation

- *How can AI engage visually, not only verbally?*

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Workshop Paper



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